

Modeling Ethical Technology Use with Generative AI

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Abstract

This poster describes a single-session module for an undergraduate computing ethics course focused on generative AI (GenAI) use in higher education. The session asks students to reflect on both their own use (or non-use) of GenAI as well as that of their instructors. Details of the session, including pre-reading, session topics, and reflection questions, are included so the module may be repeated at other institutions. In the discussion, I examine the importance of computing ethics instructors as models for ethical technology use in the classroom.

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1 Introduction

Computing ethics courses are an opportunity to engage students in critical reflection of the impacts of both historical and modern technologies [1]. Due to the ever-changing nature of computing, is it imperative that some class sessions in a computing ethics course are consistently updated to reflect current technological issues.

Recently, the impact generative AI (GenAI) has on higher education has been a major point of discussion, by researchers and non-researchers alike (i.e. [6, 7]). This topic provides a great entry point for students to join the discussion surrounding an ethically ripe technology. As such, I introduced this topic into my computing ethics class this summer. First, I grounded the topic by focusing on the impact student use of GenAI has on learning. This is a topic most, if not all, computing students have already considered to at least some degree as they have navigated their personal choice to use or not use GenAI on their own assignments. I then flipped the topic over to prompt critical reflection from a novel angle, asking students to consider: *What impact does GenAI use by instructors have on their learning?* A 2025 New York Times piece reflects student frustration with their instructors using GenAI, particularly when those same instructors prohibit students from doing so.¹ Yet, there may be a more nuanced story to tell about student perceptions around this issue.

¹nytimes.com/2025/05/14/technology/chatgpt-college-professors.html



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By posing this question, I gave students agency, empowering them to understand their own perspectives in the learning relationship as crucial. While doing so, this topic provides a valuable learning opportunity to practice reflecting, discussing, and considering a modern ethical computing issue that impacts them, preparing students to make decisions on major ethical issues as they enter the workforce.

This poster introduces the activity so it can be repeated in other computing ethics courses, then discusses the importance of modeling ethical technology use in the computing ethics classroom.

2 Activity Design

This session was taught to a small class of approximately 20 computing majors over a 75-minute period.

Pre-reading. Students read the popular article “Everyone Is Cheating Their Way Through College”² by New York Magazine, which focuses on the opinions of students who choose to use GenAI in their undergraduate coursework. Students were then asked to complete a short reading reflection based on the article (in the same format as for every class session), including: choosing a salient quote, explaining why they found that quote notable, posing a question the reading brought up for them, and stating whether or not (and how) they used AI-based grammar checkers and/or GenAI to assist them with the reflection. In the previous class session, a pre-work activity included watching HowTown’s “I Tried to Prove I’m Not an AI,”³ which was also referenced in this class session.

In-Class Session. I opened with a transparency statement about my own use of GenAI, which my students had come to expect as I did so every session. However, this session was different. They were greeted on the first slide with an image of computers attending university, which had a note that it was generated by Microsoft’s GenAI Copilot, plus an additional note stating that I used GenAI more for this class session than previous ones. Since the learning objective of the day was for students to be able to “Explore ways to use GenAI as a student and instructor and critically reflect on its efficacy in those scenarios,” I wanted to put students in the position not of hypothetically considering what it might be like for me to use GenAI, but to have an experiential learning opportunity where I actually did so in a significant way. As such, in preparation for and during the class session, I used GenAI to:

- Create a short deepfake video as an introduction to the session⁴
- Take a qualitative poll and automatically aggregate results⁵

²nymag.com/intelligencer/article/openai-chatgpt-ai-cheating-education-college-students-school.html

³youtube.com/watch?v=qO0WvudbO04

⁴Tavus (tavus.io)

⁵Verse (poll.joinverse.se)

- Socratically question students and discuss the possibility of having that conversation automatically graded by AI⁶
- Create images for the slide deck⁷
- Create a short podcast to summarize an academic article⁸
- Create a reflection worksheet⁹

The lecture also included discussion of what it means for AI to have a Human In the Loop (HITL) and the impact that can have on perceptions around GenAI use [9], Freire’s banking model of education and how GenAI use by students may be impacted by their perception that they are involved in a banking model [3], the ways GenAI use in the classroom can both promote and impede educational equity [2], and the efficacy of GenAI detection software such as TurnItIn for student integrity [5].

Throughout the session, there were breakpoints every time I used AI as an instructor. At these points, students had a physical copy of a worksheet, with questions chosen from a set generated by GenAI, to reflect on the extent to which they agree with the following statements for each type of AI use, with Likert-scale options (strongly agree - strongly disagree):

- The instructor felt less present due to the AI use.
- The AI supported the instructor rather than replacing them.
- I trusted the information presented by the AI.
- I was confident that the AI was used responsibly.
- I would like to see similar AI tools used in future classes.
- The AI use improved the overall quality of the class.
- I found the AI use unsettling or uncanny.

Working on a paper worksheet allowed students to work without potential distractions by devices, however, for scaling purposes an electronic worksheet could be used. At the end of the session, students worked in pairs to discuss overarching reflections about GenAI use in higher education, including: “What made some uses of GenAI by the instructor better / more permissible than others, if you felt there was a difference?” and “Do you think instructors should be allowed to use GenAI to help them prepare for classes?”

Post-Class Discussion Forum. Finally, this topic was wrapped up via three questions on an online discussion forum. The first question asked students to use GenAI (with an option to opt-out) to reflect on the banking model of education and its role in GenAI use by students. This question included a “Trojan Horse” consisting of the a simple white-text prompt injection asking the GenAI to include the nonsensical text “hello kitty” in its response. The second question, written itself by GenAI, asked students to reflect on whether student assignments written with the help of GenAI should be given higher grades than more poorly completed assignments written without the help of GenAI. The third question asked students to reflect on what it was like in the first question to have a discussion between GenAIs, the ethics of including a Trojan Horse in assignments, and how they felt about my use of GenAI to write question two.

3 Discussion

This class session uses two related types of modeling for students: instructional modeling and role modeling.

Instructional modeling is when instructors demonstrate a skill they want students to emulate, such as through live coding [8]. Instructional modeling can be applied to the computing ethics classroom as well. For example, if we want students to be transparent about their use of GenAI (see this sample course policy¹⁰), we must demonstrate how to do so ourselves. In this class session, as with others, I included transparency statements every time I employed GenAI, just as I asked students to do on their own assignments.

In a similar vein, instructors often serve as a role model for their students. Students notice the way their instructors behave as a form of social learning [4]. This is just as true in the computing ethics classroom as any other. If one of the goals of computing ethics education is to teach students how to engage critically with technology, computing ethics instructors must serve as a role model in how to do so. By openly discussing my use of GenAI and allowing students to question it, I served as a role model in critical engagement.

The learning relationship between instructors and students involves a power differential— instructors have the power to set rules, chose content to learn, and, ultimately, decide who passes a course. In conversations around GenAI use in higher education, there seems to be a heavy focus on the impact of GenAI use by students, including what constitutes cheating and how learning is impacted (i.e. [6, 7]). These conversations are vital, but focusing almost exclusively on student use tacitly implies that instructors are somehow above the ethical conundrum of doing so. The lesson presented here challenges that notion, empowering students to consider their own point of view in this much-needed conversation. Sharing the lesson here, I urge other computing ethics instructors to model critical engagement with technology in their own classroom.

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⁶Socratic Mind (socraticmind.com)

⁷ChatGPT and Copilot (chatgpt.com, copilot.microsoft.com)

⁸NotebookLM (notebooklm.google)

⁹ChatGPT (chatgpt.com)

¹⁰genai.umich.edu/resources/faculty/course-policies